

Preparing for Promotions Ahead of Time

Advice to get ready for a promotion, and a reality check on how they work.



GERGELY OROSZ

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Question: *I have missed out on promotions in the last cycle and am disappointed. What is your advice for maximising my chance of a promotion, next time? And what about just leaving this job, and joining somewhere else at the next level?*

Whether you're a manager or an individual contributor, the best time to start preparing for a promotion is months and sometimes even years before it's due. At most tech companies, the next cycle of promotions will not start for another several months.

In this issue we cover topics on preparing for promotions:

- **Promotion philosophy vs reality** at various types of companies.
- **Promotions at Big Tech.** How does the system work, and what are good mental models to understand the process?
- **Advice for those wanting to get promoted** on preparing ahead of time. What can – and should – you do, months ahead?
- **Advice for managers** on steps to take now to avoid surprises, so you don't see people leaving unexpectedly, come promotions time. Bonus: a promotions map template for inspiration.
- **Wait for promotion vs switching jobs?** My take on this common question.

For advice on performance reviews, see the article [Preparing for performance reviews ahead of time](#).

Promotion Philosophy vs Reality

When should someone get promoted? The reasons are similar at most companies, and tend to be one or more of these:

- **Performing at the next level:** Promote people when they are already performing as expected at the next level. Needless to say, they need to be performing above expectations at their current level.
- **Impact at the next level:** Promote people who have contributed a large enough impact to warrant the next level.
- **Business need and business case for a promotion:** The organization can justify why a promotion and budget increase for the role makes sense.
- **There is opportunity and space for a promotion.** For example, if an organization has budgeted for a Staff engineer, and a Senior engineer is operating at this level, they have the opportunity for this promotion. Having a space open that people can be promoted to is increasingly a requirement with more senior levels.
- **Raise the bar at the next level:** Though rarer, some organizations add this expectation for both promotions and hires. Google is especially known to follow this philosophy. Promotions are expected to justify the question of "how does this person raise the bar at the next level?"

In practice, however, there are several other things that need to happen for a person to get promoted:

- **Perceived impact is becoming more important** than the actual business impact at several companies. This is especially true as companies grow, and it gets harder to map the impact of a person with direct impact on the business.
- **Support from others:** promotions will only happen if decision-makers support this promotion. Who these decision makers are differs at a five-person startup than at a mega-corp of thousands.
- **Internal politics.** Politics refers to the influence and standing of the person-to-be-promoted within the organization. The more decision-makers there are in a promotion process, the more complex the organization and the more senior the position, the more complicated the politics around promotions gets.

The promotion mechanics play heavily into the reality of them. Different promotion processes reward different types of visibility.

Companies with heavy budget constraints for promotions will be places where having a politically influential manager who can make a case for your promotion, is essential.

A business case typically means convincing the manager's organizational unit leader that a more senior person is, indeed, needed to get better business results that pay for the budget increase and more. Basically, they need to prove that by paying someone more after a promotion, more money will eventually follow.

For not-yet-senior-level software engineering positions, it's rare to have this kind of budget constraint. This is because if entry-level software engineers are not promoted fast enough, they'll leave the company. It's more common for managers to have to make budget cases for senior-and-above engineers, and for managers to be promoted. In either case, a manager who is not good at making these business cases will see fewer promotions approved on their team, versus those who know how to get these approvals.

Companies where a small, managerial group makes promotion decisions with an ad hoc process, will be places where being visible to these people makes promotions much easier. If you worked on a project where you got to talk to the CTO more frequently, you'll have an upper hand on those who never interacted with anyone 'in the room.'

This type of non-structured promotion decision-making is typical for companies of up to about 50 engineers, sometimes even more. The upside of such a process is simplicity and a low admin overhead. However, it can become a biased process, and one where people with good work but little visibility, might be more overlooked than they would be with more thorough processes.

Companies where a group of managers decides promotions based on a lightweight process – such as having a short promotion case – is a bit more of a predictable process. This environment favors people who have managers who are tenured, well-

connected in the organization, and politically influential. This doesn't mean that people without such managers won't be promoted; however, new managers are often less able to show the same level of conviction for their reports, as some more experienced managers can.

Companies that run a heavyweight promotion process with the goal of reducing bias almost always have a paperwork-heavy process – self-review, manager review, peer reviews – and a panel consisting of senior engineers and managers without direct links to the candidate, to avoid bias. Companies with this kind of process include Google, and above-senior positions at Uber follow this pattern as well.

This process favors those who work on high-impact projects that are easy to quantify, those with lots of written artifacts, and managers and individual contributors who write well, and can represent themselves very well in writing.

This setup is the one where outcomes depend the least on managers, but also the one where promotion processes are very exhausting and take the longest. It's also a setup where you will need to start preparing for a promotion well before it's due; produce and organize the artifacts that will aid the case.

Hybrid models are increasingly common at large tech companies. For example, at Amazon, Uber and similar companies, promotions up to the Senior Engineer level are usually decided by a manager-only committee, at the org level. Promotions at the Staff and above-levels are typically done with an org, or company-wide committee approach. This is also the case for engineering managers, where starting at Senior Engineering Managers and above, the process becomes committee-like.

"Get promoted or get fired" is an extreme promotion philosophy some high-growth startups use for less experienced engineers. At Uber, up until 2016, the philosophy was that engineers under the senior levels should either get promoted to the next engineering level within two years, or else be put on a performance improvement plan (PIP). The idea behind this approach was that continuous growth up until the senior level was the baseline expectation.

Surprisingly, this approach worked well while the company was growing rapidly, and there was no shortage of senior-level work that people could do. As Uber's growth slowed, the policy started to make less sense. Some people were not able to get promoted because of a lack of senior-level projects in their immediate area. Managers were also forced to either game the system – promoting people to avoid PIPs – or put people with no performance issues on PIPs.

This approach of a “fixed promotion schedule” is one that several companies still use as a career growth framework for entry-level engineers.

Promotions at Big Tech

Compensation, promotions and performance and how they are connected is different at Big Tech, than at most other companies. At most “traditional” companies, getting promoted is the obvious way – and often only one – to get more compensation. End-of-year bonuses are often tied heavily to company performance, sometimes fully independent of your own, personal performance.

Big Tech takes a different view on promotions and compensation with regards to base salary, bonuses and [equity compensation](#):

- **Pay for performance** is a common approach at these companies. Your cash bonus and equity refreshers are tied to your performance, relative to your peers. The highest performing people often get outsized bonuses, 5-10x times that of the “average” bonuses.
- **Rules around promotion eligibility.** Most companies require at least a 12-month tenure in the current role to be eligible for promotion, and some also mandate that only top performers – those calibrated to be in the upper half of ratings – be nominated for promotion. While most companies publish promotion criteria, some organizations can apply more strict criteria, for example, on tenure expectations.
- **A promotion moves compensation to the beginning of the next band.** These companies have internal pay bands for base salary, and total compensation target. When someone is promoted, they receive a minimum salary increase (usually 8-10%) and are moved to somewhere near the base of the next level's compensation

band. Equity refreshers are allocated with this approach as well; promoted employees typically get some additional equity refresh, though this can be delayed by a cycle, and is often less than they hoped.

- **A top performing employee at a lower level can make more** than an average performer at the next level. For example at Uber, top performing senior engineers or engineering managers would see as much as \$320,000 in cash and equity bonuses in the US, and €170,000 in Europe. These people would make more compensation in the year than average performing engineers or managers at the next level. However, being recognized as a top performer – 3-5% of the senior engineering population – is a very hard feat.
- **Promotions are not the only way to recognize impact.** Because of pay for performance, people with high impact can be recognized with strong bonuses, retention grants and by other financial means. Starting at the senior engineering level, promotions don't become as pressing for many engineers, because the financial incentive is lower, compared to doing well at the current level.

Expectations for impact and competencies is a common way for these companies to frame performance and promotions conversations. All of them have expectations documented for all engineering and engineering management levels. To be promoted, people have to demonstrate performing at the next level on these two dimensions:

- **"What" – the impact of their work.** They are expected to demonstrate business impact at the next level. For example, for a Staff engineer, this expectation might be to deliver a long-term effort to solve a meaningful problem at the organization level. The impact of the work is typically easier to quantify for customer-facing Product work, than some Platform work. Product work is often tied to company Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) like incremental revenue or cost savings. Platform work is often tied to KPIs one level below this, like systems latency decrease, reliability increasing or developer productivity increasing.
- **"How" – measuring against the competencies.** Each company defines dimensions of expectations at each level, called competencies. For example, at Uber, these competencies were Software Engineering, Design & Architecture, Execution & Results, Collaboration, Creating Efficiency and Citizenship. Performing at the next level with these competencies almost always requires people to work

well with others and stakeholders. In practice, some of the competencies will carry more weight than others. These differences are unique to the company, the promotion process, and sometimes even to the group within the company a person works in.

One of the biggest challenges for senior, and above-senior promotions at Big Tech is the continuous increase of impact radius and the complexity of problems. For example, to get promoted to senior engineering level, one is typically expected to showcase team-level impact. Staff engineers need to show organization or company-wide impact. Senior engineering managers and directors face similarly raised expectations.

While a company is growing rapidly, there are plenty of opportunities that fit these bills. A hypergrowth company has no shortage of organization-wide woes that engineers and managers can attempt to solve. When they succeed, promotions typically follow.

However, the more mature a company becomes, the fewer these opportunities; and the more complex and time-consuming they are to solve. The opportunities might become so rare that failure is not an option, as it would blow the promotion opportunity of an engineer or manager who knows how rare these organization-wide problems are.

Having fewer "promotion-worthy" opportunities also incentivises coming up with success criteria that can turn a failing project into something that can be perceived as a success. And why would people not do so? They put in the effort and did the work; admitting the project did not succeed would result in poorer performance reviews and promotion outcomes at most places. *I'm playing devil's advocate here.*

Promotion-driven development is an unfortunate, but very real consequence of the impact-driven nature of promotions and performance reviews at Big Tech. With each level, your work is expected to impact larger groups, and drive more impactful business outcomes.

How can you impact a large group of engineers, and drive a major business outcome? An obvious answer is to solve an engineering problem the organization has. However, to get promoted, the "what" (impact) is not enough. You need to perform at the next level of the "how" (competencies) as well. In practice, this means building something

non-trivial that involves coordination of large groups, and is a difficult engineering challenge.

This is exactly why, instead of using an existing third-party framework for an organization-wide issue, engineers working towards Staff promotions will write their own, in-house solution. As justification, they will find edge cases where existing solutions do not work well enough, and they'll go ahead and execute this complex, impactful – and promotion-worthy – project.

Though at times building custom tooling is justified by unique needs, there is little to no incentive for any engineer to go with an off-the-shelf vendor solution that solves the problem. This approach would be labelled as trivial and would not meet the complexity expectations the software engineering and architecture/design competencies demand at senior and-above levels.

Promotion Driven Development is one of the reasons why all of Big Tech has built custom solutions for everything, from developer tools, through observability tools, to rebuilding products that did not take off. I'm not exaggerating: Google built [20 different chat products over 16 years](#), often in parallel. It is certain that each of these chat projects got dozens of engineers and managers promoted to the next level, before another group made the case to start a complex project from scratch with an even larger impact, instead of fixing up the existing one.

Advice for Those Wanting to Get Promoted

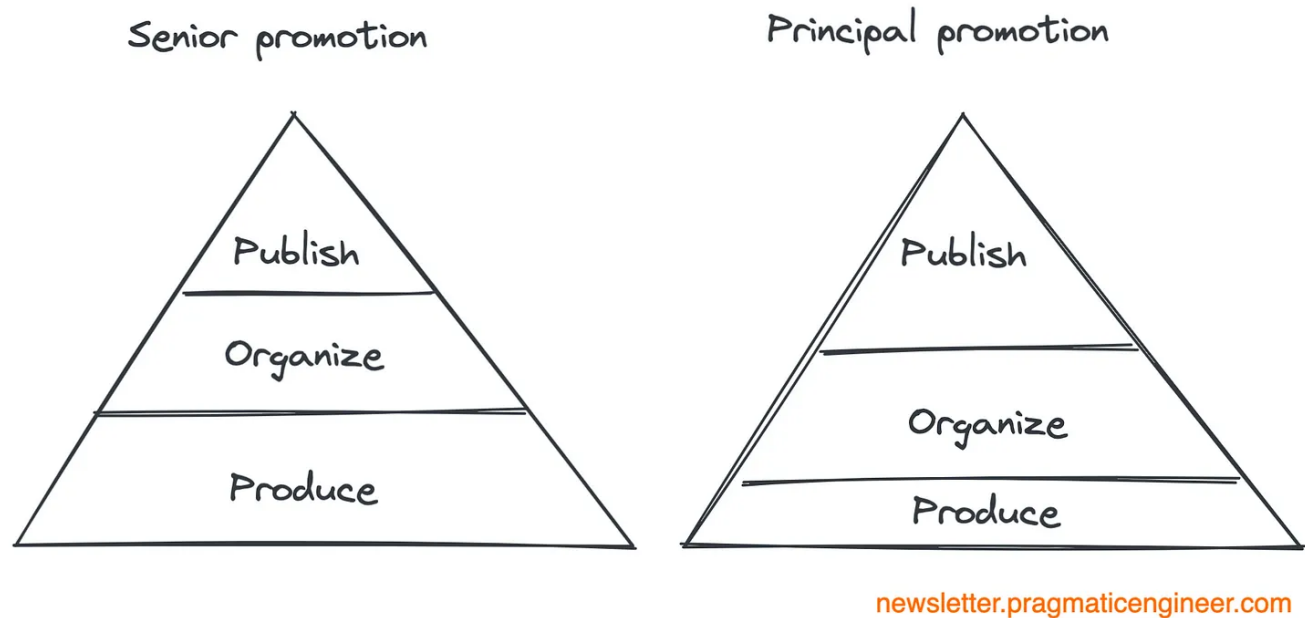
You're hoping to get promoted in the next cycle. What are things that you can do ahead of time that will increase your chances? Here are several pieces of advice.

- **Be realistic.** How was your last performance review? Did you exceed expectations? If not; there's little chance you'd be promoted. Work towards exceeding expectations for the next review cycle: much of the advice below also applies to figuring out how to do this.
- **Understand how promotions work at the company.** Who nominates? Who decides? What are the criteria? What process does your company follow?

- **Understand how promotions *really* work in practice.** The reality of who gets promoted is not always an exact mapping to the officially documented process. Talk with people who have gone through the process and with mentors you might have at the company. Common differences that are not documented can include completing a “promotion project” that is shipped to production, peer feedback being a lot less important, feedback from staff-level engineers or directors being a lot more important, or the influence of managers playing a more key role than the official guidance suggests.
- **Self-evaluate.** Assuming there’s a clear set of expectations – like the career ladder with competencies – evaluate where you think you are, compared to the current, and the next level. [This self-review template](#) might be helpful.
- **Talk with your manager.** Bring up the topic of promotions. Ask them where they think you are, and what it would take them to support. Show them your self-review. Your manager usually has the final say on the projects you work on, and if you don’t have the opportunity to work on projects that prove that you’re ready for the next level, you will not have a strong promotion case.
- **Get your manager on your side.** If they are not supportive, it will be hard, if not impossible, to get promoted. But you’re starting to work on this well ahead of decision time. How can you reassure them you’re ready? What will make them fully support your case?
- **For staff and principal engineer and engineering management promotions,** get your skip level manager on your side. Promotions that go above the senior engineering level typically have significant input from the manager chain. Having your manager on your side might not be sufficient: at the very least, your skip-level manager also needs to advocate for you. Have 1:1s with these people, and make sure they are aware of and support the work you are doing and understand its impact. If possible, try to hold a recurring 1:1 every few months.
- **When a promotion would mean a change of manager,** getting full support from your skip-level is even more important. For example, some companies have rules about Engineering Managers not being allowed to manage Staff Engineers. Should you be promoted to Staff, you would move out from reporting to your current manager. This is a delicate situation, as some managers might not see such a

promotion as in their best interest. The more challenging a promotion situation is, the more your important strong relationships and clear expectation-setting with your management chain will be.

- **Get feedback from peers.** Ask for feedback on how you're doing from your peers, especially from more senior colleagues. Come promotion time, you'll likely need peers to support your case. Get ahead of this and ask the people who would give peer feedback. "Which areas could you see me improve on further?" "Do you think I'm operating at the next level, and what gaps do you see, if not?" "What other advice do you have for me to grow?" All of these are good questions to ask.
- **Make an actionable plan.** Set goals, together with your manager to get to that next level, or closer to promotion. Do this in writing.
- **Check-in and deliver on it.** Keep them in the loop on your progress, and get feedback. It's great to do this in a document.
- **Produce, Organize, Publish** is a good framework to think about the buckets of work you do - [as phrased by](#) product leader Shreyas Doshi. It's not enough to just do good work, you need to work with others and publish your work for people to be aware of it. This framework is a good way to think about these activities:
 - *Produce* work day-to-day. This work results in artifacts like code, design docs, postmortems, code reviews and others.
 - *Organize* things that help with getting things done. This might mean organizing meetings, setting up initiatives, and introducing better ways of working within a group, such as workflow improvements or bug bashes.
 - *Publish* your work, promoting it to others. Activities that help with this include 1:1s, presenting at organization or company-wide meetings, knowledge-sharing sessions, other internal or external events, etc.
 - Your focus will shift as you become more senior to more on the Organizing and Publishing, over the Producing parts in most organizations. This is no accident. Both Staff Engineers and Directors will spend more time organizing and publishing than producing, compared to lower levels.



The produce, organize, publish framework. The more senior you are, the more you'll be expected to organize and publish at the next level.

- **Find a mentor who is at the next level.** Reach out to someone at least a level up on the career ladder, ideally someone who has been promoted to that level within the company. Set up a 1:1 and ask them if they can share their experience on growing to the next level, giving you advice and feedback. Obviously, someone like this can't "guarantee" any promotion, but you get another ally and one more person to get actionable feedback from.
- **Keep track of all your achievements.** The most practical way to do this is to write down what you did, every week. Summarize key achievements every month, then every quarter. If you're only starting now, write down your key achievements for the past year. You'll want to have examples that show that you have continuously been delivering highly impactful work.
- **Prepare: what if your manager changes?** Though it might seem unlikely now, your manager could leave your team or your company at any time. Is your promotion overly reliant on them being present to advocate for you? Change this. Make sure your work is visible not only to your manager, via 1:1s. The publishing activities in the Produce, Organize, Publish framework are key to hedge against this case.

- **Don't get overly obsessed with the promotion.** You risk alienating your manager, and your peers if you become The Person Working Just For The Promotion. Have a plan, work towards it, but avoid the perception that this is the only thing you care about. And it's not just about perception; avoid the promotion being your one and only goal. Find goals that are more in your control, and can give you more immediate satisfaction when you complete them.
- **Be realistic on promotion rates.** The higher the level you're aiming for, the smaller percentage of promotions typically go through. At most Big Tech, about 30-40% of promotion cases to senior levels tend to be rejected. This number is typically lower at levels below, and higher at levels above.
- **Prepare to not be promoted.** No promotion is a 100% done deal. Can you set goals that make you a better professional, regardless of the promotion outcome? Successfully shipping a complex and impactful project, becoming more visible inside or outside the company, or mastering a new technology are all things that make you more valuable, more employable, and more promotable both within and outside the company.
- **Help others so they can later help you.** What goes around, comes around. Helping others is not only the right thing to do, but it also builds up goodwill that will help you later on at the organization. Here are things you can do to help others:
 - Give back by mentoring someone who is a level below you. Can you help them grow to where you are now?
 - Mentor people outside your company [at one of these communities](#). You'll not only help, but you'll also learn a lot.
 - Support others whom you know are working towards a promotion. Can you give them constructive and helpful feedback, and a helping hand?
 - Volunteer to do things that help the team, which others might shy away from. At the very least, this will help the team. At the same time, managers are more likely to support promotions for people who help their whole team succeed, not only push their personal agenda.
 - Share that you are working towards a promotion with some of your teammates. If they know this is important for you, they're more likely to help you.

Advice for Managers to Prepare Ahead

As a manager, if you're only talking about promotions with people when nominations are due, you're too late. If a team member is expecting to be promoted, and finds out they will not be at the very last minute, they might look to leave your team and transfer internally. They may even leave the company. The earlier you have the conversation about the prospect of a promotion and set expectations, the better.

I suggest creating an internal "promotions map" for your personal use to visualize the career progress of each person, any past rejections, and their attrition risk. You can also spot patterns with this "map"; are some people taking longer to promote than others at the same level? Who are the people who are moving the fastest, and could they mentor others on the team? How far into the future can you map out possible promotions?

[Here is the template to use](#) (just make a copy of it):

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J
	Discipline	Current level	Attrition Risk	2019 MY	2019 EY	2020 MY	2020 EY	2021 MY	↓ 20201 EY (NEXT) ↓
Mobile									
Paul	Mobile	Sr	Low	Eng2	!★ Sr promo: reject		★ Sr promo		
Carol	Mobile	Sr	Very low	Eng2			★ Sr promo		
Lee	Mobile (iOS)	Sr	Low	Eng2		★ Sr promo			
Max	Mobile	Eng2	Very low	Eng1	Eng1	Eng1	★ Eng2 promo		
Guy	Mobile (Android)	Eng2	Low				Eng 2		
Leanne	Mobile	Eng1	Very low				Eng1		
Backend									
Roxanne	BE	Sr	High	Eng2			★ Sr promo		
Max	BE	Sr	Low			Eng2		★ Sr promo	
Zee	BE	Eng1	Low					Eng1	
Lee	BE	Eng1	Low					Eng1	
Joanne	BE	Eng1	Low						Eng1
Web									
Pauline	Web&Mobile	Staff	Medium	Sr				★ Staff promo	④ years - vesting cliff!
Max	Web	Sr	Low	Eng1	★ Eng2 promo			★ Sr promo	
Rachel	Web	Eng2	Low		Eng2			!★ Sr promo: r	★ Sr promo
Lee	Web	Eng2	High	Eng1		★ Eng2 promo			
Tom		Eng2	Very low						Eng2

Promotions map: a way to visualize career progress and expected promotion timelines of the team

Additional activities that can help you, as a manager, prepare for promotions ahead of time:

- **Make a list of people** of "definite", "maybe" and "definitely not" promotions in the next cycle.

- **Check your biases.** Is anyone on that list that you are biased towards? Is someone missing whom you are biased against? Here's my summary of the [most common performance related biases managers tend to exhibit](#) – even if they are not aware of them.
- **Review people on the list, based on these attributes:**
 - *"Definite" people to promote:* Sit down and make a plan of what they need to deliver for a high-confidence promotion case. Review blind spots, and set strategic goals. Advocate for them up your management chain.
 - *"Stuck" people:* Do you have people with long tenure, who are "behind" the average promo tenure? What will happen to them? Do they need help or support? Can you step in and mentor them, or pull in other people to help? It's especially important to identify people "stuck" before the terminal levels, above which promotions are not expected.
 - *"Maybe" people:* Make a plan of how you can decide to support a promotion or not. Work with them to see if it can be a realistic goal. The sooner you both agree if you're targeting a promotion now or later, the better.
 - *High-performing people not up for promotion:* Ensure that these people will still be recognized through compensation rewards, or in other ways that the organization supports. As you'll prepare for end-of-year performance reviews and calibrations, much of the advice for "definite people" applies, especially in advocating for them through your management chain.
- **Get a sense of promotion budgets at your organization.** Most organizations have a concept of a promotion budget; usually a percentage of the population who can be promoted, or, in some cases, a fixed monetary value that can be distributed in promotions. In practice, this means you won't be able to promote 50% of your team in a cycle. Get a sense of what this budget could look like, gathering information from your management chain and managers with longer tenure.
- **Run promotion cases by your manager for support.** Once you know which people you plan to support for promotion in the next cycle, get buy-in from your manager. Set up a session where you walk them through each person, their impact, and why they should be promoted. Aim to get feedback from your manager, and, ultimately, verbal support from them as well. Keep in mind that at

promotion time, things might shift with unexpected promotion budget changes that your manager has no control over. Still, the more your manager knows about your high performers, the better they can help advocate for them.

- **Get to know key people in the promotion process.** Who are decision makers in promotions? Who has an outsized say? Which non-engineers have outsized input? How much do Product, Design, Data Science and other disciplines count, or not count? Get to know these people, set up 1:1s and share details about your team, people going up for promotion, and the impact they are having.
- **Talk with other managers and help them.**
 - *Support your peer engineering managers* in their promotion cases. Ask them which people they plan to promote on their teams. Offer support like meeting with them directly, connecting them with mentors on your team, or offering sponsorship. This approach is SO powerful, yet barely anyone does it. Not only will you help another individual contributor, but you'll form a stronger relationship with your peer.
 - *Share who you plan to promote* with your peer engineering managers, and key stakeholders on the team like the PM and others who might be able to act on this information. Needless to say, ask for confidentiality when sharing, and do so in order that these key people might find opportunities to further support these candidates.
 - *Connect with non-engineering stakeholders* on your team. Are they expecting a promotion? Talk with people working with your team like the PM, designers, data scientists and other stakeholders. Are any of them working towards a promotion? As a manager, your input and feedback might help them, and most of them will appreciate additional support.
- **Do you have a promotion committee in your organization?** If you have not yet been on a promotion committee, getting on one could be a fantastic learning experience and one that can help you support your directs better in future promotion cycles. Talk with your manager, and your skip-level and express interest to get involved in future cycles.
- **Resist the temptation to promote to get ahead of attrition,** without merit. Especially with the hot job market, there could be people on your team who are at

risk of leaving, unless they get promoted. However, don't use promotions to fight this; use compensation adjustments or retention bonuses. Pushing for the promotion of someone who is not yet ready for the sake of keeping them, will backfire and can result in a Peter principle situation – people promoted to a level of incompetence. This is especially the case for roles which are considered highly influential ones.

Waiting for Promotions vs Switching Jobs

You feel you have what it takes to perform at the next level. Instead of waiting for months, and going through a grueling promotion process, it's so tempting to go out there, interview, and get an offer with the title you want. Who knows, maybe you'd get higher compensation as well?

It's an obvious option to interview around, especially with such a hot job market in tech. However, before starting to apply for positions, a few nuances are worth considering.

Promotions are typically backwards-looking. This means that you are expected to perform at the next level for 6-12 months, and the promotion is confirming you did so. What it also means is you might be able to move companies to that higher level, for a jump in compensation. In fact, if you are able to move to a company that is a higher tier [in this trimodal model](#), your compensation might increase significantly more.

The backwards-looking nature also means that you could progress 6-12 months faster in your early career, assuming you can get offers at the next level, instead of waiting to be promoted in your current role.

The earlier you are in your career, the less risk it is to level up by getting an offer. When you have an entry-level engineer or engineering manager position, these moves are far more straightforward, and can speed up your career trajectory in the short-term.

The more senior you are, the riskier a job change can be. This is especially true at Staff and Principal engineering levels, and at Senior Engineering Managers and above. Doing well in these roles requires you to build up a good political standing. This means

understanding how the organization works and its unwritten rules, building trust with key stakeholders, and knowing how to influence decisions that impact larger groups.

Building up a network of people you trust and who trust you, and figuring out how the organization works, takes a significant amount of time. When you switch to a new position, you have to start from scratch. Even worse, if you don't get up to speed quickly enough, you can find yourself in a stressful situation, as expectations are higher at these levels.

Tenure becomes increasingly important as you become more senior. While it is common to see early career people change jobs often, not staying at any company beyond two years can easily become a flag for above-senior engineering and engineering manager positions.

Staff and principal engineers and engineering managers need time to build connections, and to execute on longer-term, impactful projects. Driving this impact is done by understanding the context, making sense of the business, and prioritizing work correctly. Learning this usually takes at least a year at most organizations.

Tenure also brings a new, long-term perspective that leaders need to understand first-hand. By staying on the same team and at the same company for years, you see some of your early decisions come and bite you or others, years later. You understand how something no one thought much about turned into a big problem, or how doing a bit more work earlier saved a large amount of work, a year or two later.

Before quitting, consider the learning you're leaving on the table, if you have not yet spent long at a company. Building platforms that see large adoption takes years. Launching a product, then iterating through each growth stage also takes years. One of the reasons why engineers and managers who worked at the same, high-growth startup for several years become increasingly sought after, is they have seen several growth phases in one place, and now can call on that experience.

I talked with several Uber alumni who are now staff engineers, CTOs and VP of Engineering at venture-funded startups. They all told me the same thing; staying many years at Uber and going through the various phases, gives them an edge today. They

are making strategic decisions with confidence, because they know what will happen in 6, 12, 24 months from now, as they stayed long enough to see how similar decisions played out before.

Don't get me wrong, tenure is not what you want to optimize for. However, if you have been working in the industry for 8+ years, but have not spent more than 3 years at a single company, it could be a good idea to target your next position as one where you can stay for at least this long, to gain the perspective that comes with tenure.

Not having internal opportunities to grow to the next level is increasingly common, as you get more experienced, and as your organization matures. You could be up against budget constraints; for example, you might want to get to the Staff level, but there's already a Staff Engineer on your team, and there is no budget for a second one. Not having the space to grow is especially common for managers, who typically need to take on larger teams and deliver more impactful outcomes, in order to get promoted.

When you hit this wall, it can be sensible to look for external opportunities. This is especially true if your learning has slowed, or if you are determined to keep progressing in your career.

The tech job market [has never been this hot](#) for senior people, so if in doubt, now is a good time to look externally, and see what your options are. However, while the market is up compensation-wise, the employers have not changed much.

Once you get an offer, don't just assess it based on compensation, consider other dimensions important to you. These could be your ongoing career progression, the people you'd work with, challenges, company mission, work flexibility and more.

Finally, don't forget that missing a promotion in the next cycle might feel like a big deal, but ten years from now, you probably won't remember it. Play the long-game, and think about your strategy across this timeframe as well.

If you have other great advice on preparing for promotions, I'd love to hear it in the comments 🙌

Thanks to [Alessandro](#), [Andreas](#), [Igor](#), [Michał](#), [Piotr](#), [Yohan](#) and [Zeke](#) for their help in reviewing this article.

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